SOUTH INDIAN BREAKFAST COLLECTION

NO. 04



TAMIL NADU ORIGIN

Ven Pongal

Savory Rice & Lentil Porridge
with Pepper, Cumin & Ghee

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Ven Pongal

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Ven Pongal

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Comfort Food with a Harvest Soul

Pongal is both a dish and a festival, and the two are deeply intertwined. Every January, Tamil Nadu celebrates Pongal, a multi-day harvest festival giving thanks for the year's rice crop, and its centerpiece ritual is cooking a pot of rice and milk until it boils over — an auspicious sign of abundance for the year ahead. That festival dish is sweet: Sakkarai Pongal, made with jaggery, milk, and ghee.

Ven Pongal — the savory version featured in this recipe, whose name literally means "white pongal" in Tamil — grew out of the same culinary tradition but took on its own identity as a beloved everyday breakfast, far beyond festival season. Made with rice and moong dal cooked down into a soft, creamy porridge and finished with a generous tempering of black pepper, cumin, ginger, and ghee, it has none of the sweetness of its festival cousin, leaning instead into warmth and gentle spice.

Today, ven pongal is a fixture of South Indian tiffin counters, temple breakfasts, and home kitchens alike, often served alongside a tangy vada, coconut chutney, and a spiced side called gothsu — a combination many South Indians consider the ultimate comfort breakfast.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Comfort Food with a Harvest Soul, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Named for the Pongal harvest festival, though eaten year-round as an everyday breakfast dish. Traditionally offered to deities at Tamil temples, often served on a banana leaf. A classic pairing with medu vada and coconut chutney at South Indian tiffin restaurants. The sweet counterpart, Sakkarai Pongal, is specifically prepared for the festival itself and other auspicious occasions.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	25m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker (traditional method) or a heavy-bottomed pot
- Small pan for the tempering
- Wooden spoon or ladle for mashing and mixing
- Mortar and pestle, or the flat side of a knife, for crushing peppercorns

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Pongal is best served fresh and warm, as it thickens significantly on standing. It keeps refrigerated for up to 2 days — reheat with a splash of hot water or milk, stirring to loosen it back to a soft, creamy consistency. It does not freeze particularly well, as the texture turns grainy on thawing.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the pongal

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Raw rice (short-grain, or sona masoori)	1 cup	200 g	1 katori
Moong dal (split, yellow)	⅓ cup	70 g	⅓ katori
Water	4½ cups	1.1 L	4½ katori
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste
Milk — optional, for creaminess	¼ cup	60 ml	¼ katori

Tempering (tadka)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Ghee	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Black peppercorns, coarsely crushed	1½ tsp	5 g	1½ chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Fresh ginger, minced	1 tbsp	10 g	1 inch
Cashews, halved	2 tbsp	20 g	2 tbsp
Curry leaves	1–2 sprigs	10–15 leaves	1–2 sprigs
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Moong dal is widely available at any Indian or general Asian grocer, sold split and skinned yellow. If you can't find raw rice, sona masoori or even short-grain white rice both work well. Ghee is traditional and essential to the dish's flavor — while butter can substitute in a pinch, it will noticeably change the taste and richness.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Rice and Dal

01 DRY ROAST THE MOONG DAL

In a dry pan, roast the moong dal over medium-low heat for 2–3 minutes, stirring constantly, until it turns a shade darker and smells lightly toasted. This step deepens the pongal's flavor and is a traditional, non-negotiable step in most Tamil kitchens.

02 RINSE AND COMBINE

Rinse the roasted dal along with the rice until the water runs mostly clear. Combine both in a pressure cooker with the water and salt.



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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Rice and Dal, continued

03 PRESSURE COOK UNTIL SOFT

Cook for 4–5 whistles, then let the pressure release naturally. The rice and dal should be completely soft and starting to break down — pongal is meant to be soft and porridge-like, not separate grains.

Texture indicator. when you stir it, the mixture should fall in soft, creamy ribbons off the spoon rather than holding a firm shape.

04 MASH TO A CREAMY CONSISTENCY

While still warm, mash the mixture lightly with the back of a ladle or spoon. Stir in the milk if using, for extra creaminess, and adjust with a little hot water if the texture feels too thick.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

The Tempering

05 TOAST THE PEPPER AND CUMIN

Heat the ghee in a small pan over medium heat. Add the crushed peppercorns and cumin seeds, toasting for about 30 seconds until fragrant — you should hear a gentle crackle.



06 ADD GINGER, CASHEWS, AND CURRY LEAVES

Add the minced ginger and cashews, stirring until the cashews turn golden brown, about 1–2 minutes. Add the curry leaves and asafoetida last — they should sizzle immediately on contact with the hot ghee.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

The Tempering, continued

07 FOLD THE TEMPERING INTO THE PONGAL

Pour the entire tempering, ghee and all, over the mashed rice and dal, and fold it through gently to distribute evenly. Taste and adjust salt and pepper before serving.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Skimping on ghee is the most common mistake — pongal relies on a generous amount for both flavor and its signature glossy finish. This is not a dish to make diet-conscious substitutions in; save the lighter cooking for another day.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot on a banana leaf with sambar, coconut chutney, and a crisp medu vada.
- Often paired with gothsu, a tangy brinjal-and-tomato side dish.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- A generous scoop plated with small bowls of sambar and chutney, garnished with extra cashews and curry leaves.

Family Style

- Served straight from the pot at the table, with everyone helping themselves alongside shared sides.

Modern Pairing

- Works well as a comforting, mild breakfast bowl on its own, topped with a fried egg for a fusion twist (non-traditional, but popular in modern homes).

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Flavor Balancing

- Freshly crushed pepper, rather than pre-ground, makes a noticeable difference in aroma and heat.
- A touch of milk stirred in at the end gives restaurant-style pongal its signature glossy creaminess.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Roast a large batch of moong dal ahead of time and store it — it keeps well and shaves a step off future mornings.
- Pongal thickens as it sits, so always keep a little extra hot water or milk on hand to loosen it before serving.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some tiffin restaurants finish the dish with an extra spoonful of raw ghee drizzled on top just before serving — a small touch that adds noticeable richness and shine.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

280 kcal	7 g	42 g	9 g	2.5 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with ghee quantity.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten, Tree nuts. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Sakkarai Pongal	the sweet festival counterpart, made with jaggery, milk, cardamom, and generous ghee.
Milagu Pongal	an extra-peppery version with double the crushed black pepper.
Temple-Style Pongal	often made with more ghee and a simpler tempering, offered as prasadam (blessed food).
Millet Pongal	a modern, health-conscious variation substituting rice with millets like foxtail or little millet.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

My pongal turned out too thick – how do I fix it?

Stir in hot water or milk a little at a time until it loosens back to a soft, creamy consistency. Pongal thickens quickly as it cools, so this is completely normal.

Can I make this without a pressure cooker?

Yes — simmer the rice and dal in a covered pot with extra water for 25–30 minutes, stirring occasionally, until soft and creamy.

Is ven pongal the same as khichdi?

They're cousins, both being rice-and-lentil porridges, but ven pongal is distinctly South Indian in its pepper-cumin-ghee tempering, while khichdi varies widely by region and often includes different spices and vegetables.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Ven Pongal	"white pongal" — the savory rice and lentil dish featured in this recipe.
Sakkarai Pongal	the sweet, jaggery-based festival version of pongal.
Moong dal	split, skinned yellow lentil used for its mild flavor and quick cooking.
Gothsu	a tangy brinjal-and-tomato side dish traditionally served with pongal.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Ven Pongal

10m	25m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

PONGAL

Raw rice	200 g
Moong dal	70 g
Water	1.1 L
Salt	6 g
Milk — optional	60 ml

TEMPERING (TADKA)

Ghee	45 ml
Black peppercorns	5 g
Cumin seeds	4 g
Fresh ginger	10 g
Cashews	20 g
Curry leaves	10–15 leaves
Asafoetida	pinch

METHOD

01 **Dry roast the moong dal.** In a dry pan, roast the moong dal over medium-low heat for 2–3 minutes, stirring constantly, until it turns a shade darker and smells lightly toasted.

02 **Rinse and combine.** Rinse the roasted dal along with the rice until the water runs mostly clear.

03 **Pressure cook until soft.** Cook for 4–5 whistles, then let the pressure release naturally.

04 **Mash to a creamy consistency.** While still warm, mash the mixture lightly with the back of a ladle or spoon.

05 **Toast the pepper and cumin.** Heat the ghee in a small pan over medium heat.

06 **Add ginger, cashews, and curry leaves.** Add the minced ginger and cashews, stirring until the cashews turn golden brown, about 1–2 minutes.

07 **Fold the tempering into the pongal.** Pour the entire tempering, ghee and all, over the mashed rice and dal, and fold it through gently to distribute evenly.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Raw rice	200 g	☐ Moong dal	70 g
☐ Salt	6 g	☐ Milk — optional	60 ml
☐ Ghee	45 ml	☐ Black peppercorns	5 g
☐ Cumin seeds	4 g	☐ Fresh ginger	10 g
☐ Cashews	20 g	☐ Curry leaves	10–15 leaves
☐ Asafoetida	pinch		

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